

» MATCH OF THE
FORTNIGHT

Jude shock: The in-form Englishman lashed the ball in the top corner in the dying minutes of the game to seal the win. AFP

THE LOS BLANCOS ARE CLOSER THAN
EVER TO THEIR 36TH LA LIGA TITLE

REAL ADVANTAGE

Jude Bellingham scored a **late stunner** to effectively end Barcelona's chances of winning any trophy this season.

With a stoppage-time winner and a goal controversially ruled out, the season's final El Clasico did not disappoint, as Real Madrid beat Barcelona 3-2 to almost confirm its 36th league title.

Barcelona, now 11 points behind its arch-rival and table-topper Real Madrid, needed a win to keep itself alive in the title. But a spirited performance by the *Los Blancos* in front of their home crowd meant that Xavi will most likely depart Barca without a trophy in his final season.

It was the Blaugranas who broke the deadlock first. Andreas Christensen got at the end of Raphinha's corner to find the net with a powerful header in the sixth minute.

With an early goal, the intent was clear from Xavi's men — to grab a second and build momentum. But as it is often seen, Madrid's resolve to get back into the match bore fruit when Pau Cubarsi brought down Lucas Vazquez inside the box with a mistimed challenge, prompting the referee to point to the spot

immediately.

Vinicius Jr stepped up to take the penalty and kept his calm to slot the ball in the bottom-right corner, with Ter Stegen diving into the right direction but failing to get his hand to the ball.

With the scores level, the match was poised to churn out a thriller, but **a controversial moment in the 28th minute raised further questions about La Liga's refusal to embrace modern technology.**

Lamine Yamal flicked the ball towards the goal from Raphinha's corner, and it appeared to have crossed the line before Real Madrid keeper Andriy Lunin parried the ball to safety. While Barcelona players appealed for a goal, the match officials seemed unsure of the outcome due to the absence of the